

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Probity: Concept and Philosophical Basis of Governance - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Probity: Concept and Philosophical Basis of Governance

TEN-SESSION CORE PATH • PRACTICE • OPTIONAL ADVANCED • REGISTER NOTES

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| 1 Probity in the UPSC syllabus and the public-office setting | 2 Honesty, integrity, propriety, accountability and their overlap |
| 3 How entrusted public power turns character into a governance question | 4 Indian applications: disclosure, reasons, audit and conflict control |
| 5 Prelims facts, legal distinctions and close-option traps | 6 PYQ routes, answer theses and cross-topic boundaries |
| 7 Probable questions and exam entry points | 8 Philosophical foundations: duty, virtue, trusteeship and constitutional morality |
| 9 Procedural and substantive probity under risk-graded scrutiny | 10 Current procurement anchor, advanced limits and final synthesis |

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Probity: Concept and Philosophical Basis of Governance - Solved Practice Workbook

Generation: learner-v2:g1 **PYQ ownership:** Questions labelled as official reproduce the locally held UPSC GS-IV papers; routed historical demands are explicitly neutral renderings rather than invented quotations.

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

MCQ 1

A candidate writes only about private friendship and personal manners when asked about probity in governance. Which scope correction is required? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The UPSC clause joins the philosophical basis of governance with probity in governance, so the controlling setting is entrusted public office and the institutions that make public power upright, impartial, public-purpose and reviewable.
- B. A working definition of probity is upright, impartial and public-purpose conduct in entrusted public office, supported by reasons and records that make the exercise of power capable of public justification and appropriate verification.
- C. Honesty concerns truthfulness, non-deception and candid disclosure, including disclosure of a relevant private interest; it overlaps with integrity and probity but should not be described as a subset in a rigid hierarchy.
- D. Integrity ordinarily means consistent adherence to ethical principle and resistance to improper influence; the Nolan wording reproduced by the ARC specifically stresses freedom from outside obligations influencing official duty and does not exhaust the concept.

Answer: A

Explanation: The syllabus clause is about governance and public office is the controlling principle. The UPSC clause joins the philosophical basis of governance with probity in governance, so the controlling setting is entrusted public office and the institutions that make public power upright, impartial, public-purpose and reviewable. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 2

An officer exercises statutory licensing power affecting citizens and public resources. Which syllabus setting makes her conduct a probity question? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Honesty concerns truthfulness, non-deception and candid disclosure, including disclosure of a relevant private interest; it overlaps with integrity and probity but should not be described as a subset in a rigid hierarchy.
- B. The UPSC clause joins the philosophical basis of governance with probity in governance, so the controlling setting is entrusted public office and the institutions that make public power upright, impartial, public-purpose and reviewable.
- C. Integrity ordinarily means consistent adherence to ethical principle and resistance to improper influence; the Nolan wording reproduced by the ARC specifically stresses freedom from outside obligations influencing official duty and does not exhaust the concept.
- D. A working definition of probity is upright, impartial and public-purpose conduct in entrusted public office, supported by reasons and records that make the exercise of power capable of public justification and appropriate verification.

Answer: B

Explanation: The syllabus clause is about governance and public office is the controlling principle. The UPSC clause joins the philosophical basis of governance with probity in governance, so the controlling setting is entrusted public office and the institutions that make public power upright, impartial, public-purpose and reviewable. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 3

A district officer records objective reasons for a discretionary allotment and permits review. Which working definition best captures the standard displayed? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The UPSC clause joins the philosophical basis of governance with probity in governance, so the controlling setting is entrusted public office and the institutions that make public power upright, impartial, public-purpose and reviewable.
- B. Honesty concerns truthfulness, non-deception and candid disclosure, including disclosure of a relevant private interest; it overlaps with integrity and probity but should not be described as a subset in a rigid hierarchy.
- C. A working definition of probity is upright, impartial and public-purpose conduct in entrusted public office, supported by reasons and records that make the exercise of power capable of public justification and appropriate verification.
- D. Integrity ordinarily means consistent adherence to ethical principle and resistance to improper influence; the Nolan wording reproduced by the ARC specifically stresses freedom from outside obligations influencing official duty and does not exhaust the concept.

Answer: C

Explanation: Probity is upright public-purpose conduct capable of justification is the controlling principle. A working definition of probity is upright, impartial and public-purpose conduct in entrusted public office, supported by reasons and records that make the exercise of power capable of public justification and appropriate verification. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 4

An official claims that good intentions alone establish probity although no decision trail exists. Which definition reveals the missing public dimension? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Honesty concerns truthfulness, non-deception and candid disclosure, including disclosure of a relevant private interest; it overlaps with integrity and probity but should not be described as a subset in a rigid hierarchy.
- B. Integrity ordinarily means consistent adherence to ethical principle and resistance to improper influence; the Nolan wording reproduced by the ARC specifically stresses freedom from outside obligations influencing official duty and does not exhaust the concept.
- C. The UPSC clause joins the philosophical basis of governance with probity in governance, so the controlling setting is entrusted public office and the institutions that make public power upright, impartial, public-purpose and reviewable.
- D. A working definition of probity is upright, impartial and public-purpose conduct in entrusted public office, supported by reasons and records that make the exercise of power capable of public justification and appropriate verification.

Answer: D

Explanation: Probity is upright public-purpose conduct capable of justification is the controlling principle. A working definition of probity is upright, impartial and public-purpose conduct in entrusted public office, supported by reasons and records that make the exercise of power capable of public justification and appropriate verification. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 5

A licensing officer truthfully declares that her spouse owns shares in an applicant company. Which ethical quality is directly demonstrated by the declaration? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Honesty concerns truthfulness, non-deception and candid disclosure, including disclosure of a relevant private interest; it overlaps with integrity and probity but should not be described as a subset in a rigid hierarchy.
- B. The UPSC clause joins the philosophical basis of governance with probity in governance, so the controlling setting is entrusted public office and the institutions that make public power upright, impartial, public-purpose and reviewable.
- C. A working definition of probity is upright, impartial and public-purpose conduct in entrusted public office, supported by reasons and records that make the exercise of power capable of public justification and appropriate verification.
- D. Integrity ordinarily means consistent adherence to ethical principle and resistance to improper influence; the Nolan wording reproduced by the ARC specifically stresses freedom from outside obligations influencing official duty and does not exhaust the concept.

Answer: A

Explanation: Honesty tests truthfulness and non-deception is the controlling principle. Honesty concerns truthfulness, non-deception and candid disclosure, including disclosure of a relevant private interest; it overlaps with integrity and probity but should not be described as a subset in a rigid hierarchy. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 6

A training note says honesty is merely a subset of integrity and has no independent question. Which non-hierarchical distinction corrects it? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A working definition of probity is upright, impartial and public-purpose conduct in entrusted public office, supported by reasons and records that make the exercise of power capable of public justification and appropriate verification.
- B. Honesty concerns truthfulness, non-deception and candid disclosure, including disclosure of a relevant private interest; it overlaps with integrity and probity but should not be described as a subset in a rigid hierarchy.
- C. Integrity ordinarily means consistent adherence to ethical principle and resistance to improper influence; the Nolan wording reproduced by the ARC specifically stresses freedom from outside obligations influencing official duty and does not exhaust the concept.
- D. The UPSC clause joins the philosophical basis of governance with probity in governance, so the controlling setting is entrusted public office and the institutions that make public power upright, impartial, public-purpose and reviewable.

Answer: B

Explanation: Honesty tests truthfulness and non-deception is the controlling principle. Honesty concerns truthfulness, non-deception and candid disclosure, including disclosure of a relevant private interest; it overlaps with integrity and probity but should not be described as a subset in a rigid hierarchy. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 7

An official refuses a benefactor's request because gratitude must not influence a statutory decision. Which Nolan-linked aspect of integrity is most directly involved? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The UPSC clause joins the philosophical basis of governance with probity in governance, so the controlling setting is entrusted public office and the institutions that make public power upright, impartial, public-purpose and reviewable.
- B. A working definition of probity is upright, impartial and public-purpose conduct in entrusted public office, supported by reasons and records that make the exercise of power capable of public justification and appropriate verification.
- C. Integrity ordinarily means consistent adherence to ethical principle and resistance to improper influence; the Nolan wording reproduced by the ARC specifically stresses freedom from outside obligations influencing official duty and does not exhaust the concept.
- D. Honesty concerns truthfulness, non-deception and candid disclosure, including disclosure of a relevant private interest; it overlaps with integrity and probity but should not be described as a subset in a rigid hierarchy.

Answer: C

Explanation: Integrity is broader than the bounded Nolan formulation is the controlling principle. Integrity ordinarily means consistent adherence to ethical principle and resistance to improper influence; the Nolan wording reproduced by the ARC specifically stresses freedom from outside obligations influencing official duty and does not exhaust the concept. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 8

A note treats the Nolan outside-obligations sentence as the complete universal definition of integrity. Which bounded-reading caution applies? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A working definition of probity is upright, impartial and public-purpose conduct in entrusted public office, supported by reasons and records that make the exercise of power capable of public justification and appropriate verification.
- B. Honesty concerns truthfulness, non-deception and candid disclosure, including disclosure of a relevant private interest; it overlaps with integrity and probity but should not be described as a subset in a rigid hierarchy.
- C. The UPSC clause joins the philosophical basis of governance with probity in governance, so the controlling setting is entrusted public office and the institutions that make public power upright, impartial, public-purpose and reviewable.
- D. Integrity ordinarily means consistent adherence to ethical principle and resistance to improper influence; the Nolan wording reproduced by the ARC specifically stresses freedom from outside obligations influencing official duty and does not exhaust the concept.

Answer: D

Explanation: Integrity is broader than the bounded Nolan formulation is the controlling principle. Integrity ordinarily means consistent adherence to ethical principle and resistance to improper influence; the Nolan wording reproduced by the ARC specifically stresses freedom from outside obligations influencing official duty and does not exhaust the concept. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 9

A minister lawfully uses a broad hospitality allowance for a bidder's luxury event during evaluation. Which ethical test remains even before illegality is proved? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Propriety asks whether conduct is appropriate, fair and compatible with the purpose of entrusted power, including cases where an act may be technically lawful yet create favouritism, extravagance or misuse of institutional position.
- B. Accountability means answerability to a competent forum able to examine reasons and evidence and secure correction, remedy or consequence; publication alone increases transparency but does not complete the accountability relationship.
- C. Honesty, integrity, propriety, transparency, accountability and probity overlap and support one another, but they ask different functional questions; a sound answer compares their tests instead of arranging them as rigid nested sets.
- D. Public authority, discretion, information and money are entrusted powers rather than personal property; probity therefore forbids extraction of private advantage and demands use directed to the authorised public purpose.

Answer: A

Explanation: **Propriety asks whether lawful conduct is appropriate** is the controlling principle. Propriety asks whether conduct is appropriate, fair and compatible with the purpose of entrusted power, including cases where an act may be technically lawful yet create favouritism, extravagance or misuse of institutional position. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 10

An authority asks only whether expenditure was formally authorised, not whether it served the entrusted public purpose. Which governance concept has been omitted? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Honesty, integrity, propriety, transparency, accountability and probity overlap and support one another, but they ask different functional questions; a sound answer compares their tests instead of arranging them as rigid nested sets.
- B. Propriety asks whether conduct is appropriate, fair and compatible with the purpose of entrusted power, including cases where an act may be technically lawful yet create favouritism, extravagance or misuse of institutional position.
- C. Public authority, discretion, information and money are entrusted powers rather than personal property; probity therefore forbids extraction of private advantage and demands use directed to the authorised public purpose.
- D. Accountability means answerability to a competent forum able to examine reasons and evidence and secure correction, remedy or consequence; publication alone increases transparency but does not complete the accountability relationship.

Answer: B

Explanation: **Propriety asks whether lawful conduct is appropriate** is the controlling principle. Propriety asks whether conduct is appropriate, fair and compatible with the purpose of entrusted power, including cases where an act may be technically lawful yet create favouritism, extravagance or misuse of institutional position. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 11

A department uploads expenditure data but provides no hearing, audit response or corrective authority. Which element beyond transparency remains absent? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Propriety asks whether conduct is appropriate, fair and compatible with the purpose of entrusted power, including cases where an act may be technically lawful yet create favouritism, extravagance or misuse of institutional position.
- B. Honesty, integrity, propriety, transparency, accountability and probity overlap and support one another, but they ask different functional questions; a sound answer compares their tests instead of arranging them as rigid nested sets.
- C. Accountability means answerability to a competent forum able to examine reasons and evidence and secure correction, remedy or consequence; publication alone increases transparency but does not complete the accountability relationship.
- D. Public authority, discretion, information and money are entrusted powers rather than personal property; probity therefore forbids extraction of private advantage and demands use directed to the authorised public purpose.

Answer: C

Explanation: Accountability requires answerability plus correction is the controlling principle. Accountability means answerability to a competent forum able to examine reasons and evidence and secure correction, remedy or consequence; publication alone increases transparency but does not complete the accountability relationship. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 12

A review body can inspect reasons, order correction and refer supported misconduct for action. Which concept is institutionalised? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Honesty, integrity, propriety, transparency, accountability and probity overlap and support one another, but they ask different functional questions; a sound answer compares their tests instead of arranging them as rigid nested sets.
- B. Public authority, discretion, information and money are entrusted powers rather than personal property; probity therefore forbids extraction of private advantage and demands use directed to the authorised public purpose.
- C. Propriety asks whether conduct is appropriate, fair and compatible with the purpose of entrusted power, including cases where an act may be technically lawful yet create favouritism, extravagance or misuse of institutional position.
- D. Accountability means answerability to a competent forum able to examine reasons and evidence and secure correction, remedy or consequence; publication alone increases transparency but does not complete the accountability relationship.

Answer: D

Explanation: Accountability requires answerability plus correction is the controlling principle. Accountability means answerability to a competent forum able to examine reasons and evidence and secure correction, remedy or consequence; publication alone increases transparency but does not complete the accountability relationship. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 13

An officer is truthful about a conflict yet refuses to recuse and leaves the decision unreviewable. Which overlap analysis explains why honesty alone is insufficient? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Honesty, integrity, propriety, transparency, accountability and probity overlap and support one another, but they ask different functional questions; a sound answer compares their tests instead of arranging them as rigid nested sets.
- B. Propriety asks whether conduct is appropriate, fair and compatible with the purpose of entrusted power, including cases where an act may be technically lawful yet create favouritism, extravagance or misuse of institutional position.
- C. Accountability means answerability to a competent forum able to examine reasons and evidence and secure correction, remedy or consequence; publication alone increases transparency but does not complete the accountability relationship.
- D. Public authority, discretion, information and money are entrusted powers rather than personal property; probity therefore forbids extraction of private advantage and demands use directed to the authorised public purpose.

Answer: A

Explanation: Probity concepts overlap without a strict hierarchy is the controlling principle. Honesty, integrity, propriety, transparency, accountability and probity overlap and support one another, but they ask different functional questions; a sound answer compares their tests instead of arranging them as rigid nested sets. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 14

A candidate draws honesty inside integrity inside probity as universally settled doctrine. Which conceptual correction should replace the diagram? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Accountability means answerability to a competent forum able to examine reasons and evidence and secure correction, remedy or consequence; publication alone increases transparency but does not complete the accountability relationship.
- B. Honesty, integrity, propriety, transparency, accountability and probity overlap and support one another, but they ask different functional questions; a sound answer compares their tests instead of arranging them as rigid nested sets.
- C. Public authority, discretion, information and money are entrusted powers rather than personal property; probity therefore forbids extraction of private advantage and demands use directed to the authorised public purpose.
- D. Propriety asks whether conduct is appropriate, fair and compatible with the purpose of entrusted power, including cases where an act may be technically lawful yet create favouritism, extravagance or misuse of institutional position.

Answer: B

Explanation: Probity concepts overlap without a strict hierarchy is the controlling principle. Honesty, integrity, propriety, transparency, accountability and probity overlap and support one another, but they ask different functional questions; a sound answer compares their tests instead of arranging them as rigid nested sets. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 15

A regulator shares confidential applicant data with a relative to create a commercial opportunity. Which entrusted-power principle is violated? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Propriety asks whether conduct is appropriate, fair and compatible with the purpose of entrusted power, including cases where an act may be technically lawful yet create favouritism, extravagance or misuse of institutional position.
- B. Accountability means answerability to a competent forum able to examine reasons and evidence and secure correction, remedy or consequence; publication alone increases transparency but does not complete the accountability relationship.
- C. Public authority, discretion, information and money are entrusted powers rather than personal property; probity therefore forbids extraction of private advantage and demands use directed to the authorised public purpose.
- D. Honesty, integrity, propriety, transparency, accountability and probity overlap and support one another, but they ask different functional questions; a sound answer compares their tests instead of arranging them as rigid nested sets.

Answer: C

Explanation: Entrusted power must be used for citizens and public purpose is the controlling principle. Public authority, discretion, information and money are entrusted powers rather than personal property; probity therefore forbids extraction of private advantage and demands use directed to the authorised public purpose. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 16

A civil servant treats a discretionary quota as a personal favour bank. Which view of public office most precisely exposes the error? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Accountability means answerability to a competent forum able to examine reasons and evidence and secure correction, remedy or consequence; publication alone increases transparency but does not complete the accountability relationship.
- B. Honesty, integrity, propriety, transparency, accountability and probity overlap and support one another, but they ask different functional questions; a sound answer compares their tests instead of arranging them as rigid nested sets.
- C. Propriety asks whether conduct is appropriate, fair and compatible with the purpose of entrusted power, including cases where an act may be technically lawful yet create favouritism, extravagance or misuse of institutional position.
- D. Public authority, discretion, information and money are entrusted powers rather than personal property; probity therefore forbids extraction of private advantage and demands use directed to the authorised public purpose.

Answer: D

Explanation: Entrusted power must be used for citizens and public purpose is the controlling principle. Public authority, discretion, information and money are entrusted powers rather than personal property; probity therefore forbids extraction of private advantage and demands use directed to the authorised public purpose. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 17

An essay uses trusteeship to explain why office cannot be converted into personal entitlement. Which qualification prevents doctrinal overclaiming? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Public-office-as-trust is an ethical fiduciary analogy: officials hold authority for citizens and public purpose. The settled Indian environmental public-trust doctrine concerns State trusteeship of certain natural resources and does not directly govern every public-office decision.
- B. A deontological basis treats truthful, impartial and non-corrupt exercise of public power as a duty owed to persons and constitutional office, not merely as conduct justified when it produces convenient results or avoids detection.
- C. Virtue ethics understands probity as a stable public character cultivated through practice, while phronesis supplies practical wisdom to apply honesty, fairness and public purpose sensitively rather than through mechanical rule worship.
- D. Gandhian trusteeship treats possession and power as stewardship for social welfare, while the unity of means and ends rejects corrupt methods for desirable outcomes; applied to governance, both ideas support public-purpose administration without converting analogy into positive law.

Answer: A

Explanation: Public office as trust is an ethical analogy with a legal boundary is the controlling principle. Public-office-as-trust is an ethical fiduciary analogy: officials hold authority for citizens and public purpose. The settled Indian environmental public-trust doctrine concerns State trusteeship of certain natural resources and does not directly govern every public-office decision. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 18

A candidate asserts that M.C. Mehta v. Kamal Nath directly supplies the legal rule for every transfer and tax decision. Which boundary has been crossed? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Virtue ethics understands probity as a stable public character cultivated through practice, while phronesis supplies practical wisdom to apply honesty, fairness and public purpose sensitively rather than through mechanical rule worship.
- B. Public-office-as-trust is an ethical fiduciary analogy: officials hold authority for citizens and public purpose. The settled Indian environmental public-trust doctrine concerns State trusteeship of certain natural resources and does not directly govern every public-office decision.
- C. Gandhian trusteeship treats possession and power as stewardship for social welfare, while the unity of means and ends rejects corrupt methods for desirable outcomes; applied to governance, both ideas support public-purpose administration without converting analogy into positive law.
- D. A deontological basis treats truthful, impartial and non-corrupt exercise of public power as a duty owed to persons and constitutional office, not merely as conduct justified when it produces convenient results or avoids detection.

Answer: B

Explanation: Public office as trust is an ethical analogy with a legal boundary is the controlling principle. Public-office-as-trust is an ethical fiduciary analogy: officials hold authority for citizens and public purpose. The settled Indian environmental public-trust doctrine concerns State trusteeship of certain natural resources and does not directly govern every public-office decision. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 19

An officer refuses to manipulate a record even though concealment would save the department embarrassment. Which philosophical basis controls the refusal? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Public-office-as-trust is an ethical fiduciary analogy: officials hold authority for citizens and public purpose. The settled Indian environmental public-trust doctrine concerns State trusteeship of certain natural resources and does not directly govern every public-office decision.
- B. Virtue ethics understands probity as a stable public character cultivated through practice, while phronesis supplies practical wisdom to apply honesty, fairness and public purpose sensitively rather than through mechanical rule worship.
- C. A deontological basis treats truthful, impartial and non-corrupt exercise of public power as a duty owed to persons and constitutional office, not merely as conduct justified when it produces convenient results or avoids detection.
- D. Gandhian trusteeship treats possession and power as stewardship for social welfare, while the unity of means and ends rejects corrupt methods for desirable outcomes; applied to governance, both ideas support public-purpose administration without converting analogy into positive law.

Answer: C

Explanation: Deontology grounds probity in duty independent of detection is the controlling principle. A deontological basis treats truthful, impartial and non-corrupt exercise of public power as a duty owed to persons and constitutional office, not merely as conduct justified when it produces convenient results or avoids detection. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 20

A procurement official asks only whether bid-rigging will be discovered or improve price. Which duty-based question is missing? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Virtue ethics understands probity as a stable public character cultivated through practice, while phronesis supplies practical wisdom to apply honesty, fairness and public purpose sensitively rather than through mechanical rule worship.
- B. Gandhian trusteeship treats possession and power as stewardship for social welfare, while the unity of means and ends rejects corrupt methods for desirable outcomes; applied to governance, both ideas support public-purpose administration without converting analogy into positive law.
- C. Public-office-as-trust is an ethical fiduciary analogy: officials hold authority for citizens and public purpose. The settled Indian environmental public-trust doctrine concerns State trusteeship of certain natural resources and does not directly govern every public-office decision.
- D. A deontological basis treats truthful, impartial and non-corrupt exercise of public power as a duty owed to persons and constitutional office, not merely as conduct justified when it produces convenient results or avoids detection.

Answer: D

Explanation: Deontology grounds probity in duty independent of detection is the controlling principle. A deontological basis treats truthful, impartial and non-corrupt exercise of public power as a duty owed to persons and constitutional office, not merely as conduct justified when it produces convenient results or avoids detection. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 21

An experienced officer identifies the fair lawful course in an unusual relief case without abandoning reasons or review. Which virtue-ethics idea explains the judgment? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Virtue ethics understands probity as a stable public character cultivated through practice, while phronesis supplies practical wisdom to apply honesty, fairness and public purpose sensitively rather than through mechanical rule worship.
- B. Public-office-as-trust is an ethical fiduciary analogy: officials hold authority for citizens and public purpose. The settled Indian environmental public-trust doctrine concerns State trusteeship of certain natural resources and does not directly govern every public-office decision.
- C. A deontological basis treats truthful, impartial and non-corrupt exercise of public power as a duty owed to persons and constitutional office, not merely as conduct justified when it produces convenient results or avoids detection.
- D. Gandhian trusteeship treats possession and power as stewardship for social welfare, while the unity of means and ends rejects corrupt methods for desirable outcomes; applied to governance, both ideas support public-purpose administration without converting analogy into positive law.

Answer: A

Explanation: Virtue ethics adds habituation and practical wisdom is the controlling principle. Virtue ethics understands probity as a stable public character cultivated through practice, while phronesis supplies practical wisdom to apply honesty, fairness and public purpose sensitively rather than through mechanical rule worship. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 22

A trainee knows every conduct rule but changes principles whenever supervision disappears. Which character-based account reveals the deficit? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A deontological basis treats truthful, impartial and non-corrupt exercise of public power as a duty owed to persons and constitutional office, not merely as conduct justified when it produces convenient results or avoids detection.
- B. Virtue ethics understands probity as a stable public character cultivated through practice, while phronesis supplies practical wisdom to apply honesty, fairness and public purpose sensitively rather than through mechanical rule worship.
- C. Gandhian trusteeship treats possession and power as stewardship for social welfare, while the unity of means and ends rejects corrupt methods for desirable outcomes; applied to governance, both ideas support public-purpose administration without converting analogy into positive law.
- D. Public-office-as-trust is an ethical fiduciary analogy: officials hold authority for citizens and public purpose. The settled Indian environmental public-trust doctrine concerns State trusteeship of certain natural resources and does not directly govern every public-office decision.

Answer: B

Explanation: Virtue ethics adds habituation and practical wisdom is the controlling principle. Virtue ethics understands probity as a stable public character cultivated through practice, while phronesis supplies practical wisdom to apply honesty, fairness and public purpose sensitively rather than through mechanical rule worship. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 23

An officer takes an illegal donation to fund a genuinely useful clinic. Which Gandhian means-ends principle rejects the defence? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Public-office-as-trust is an ethical fiduciary analogy: officials hold authority for citizens and public purpose. The settled Indian environmental public-trust doctrine concerns State trusteeship of certain natural resources and does not directly govern every public-office decision.
- B. A deontological basis treats truthful, impartial and non-corrupt exercise of public power as a duty owed to persons and constitutional office, not merely as conduct justified when it produces convenient results or avoids detection.
- C. Gandhian trusteeship treats possession and power as stewardship for social welfare, while the unity of means and ends rejects corrupt methods for desirable outcomes; applied to governance, both ideas support public-purpose administration without converting analogy into positive law.
- D. Virtue ethics understands probity as a stable public character cultivated through practice, while phronesis supplies practical wisdom to apply honesty, fairness and public purpose sensitively rather than through mechanical rule worship.

Answer: C

Explanation: Gandhian trusteeship joins means, ends and stewardship is the controlling principle. Gandhian trusteeship treats possession and power as stewardship for social welfare, while the unity of means and ends rejects corrupt methods for desirable outcomes; applied to governance, both ideas support public-purpose administration without converting analogy into positive law. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 24

A public corporation treats surplus and authority as resources to be responsibly administered for society. Which Gandhian philosophical link is being used? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A deontological basis treats truthful, impartial and non-corrupt exercise of public power as a duty owed to persons and constitutional office, not merely as conduct justified when it produces convenient results or avoids detection.
- B. Virtue ethics understands probity as a stable public character cultivated through practice, while phronesis supplies practical wisdom to apply honesty, fairness and public purpose sensitively rather than through mechanical rule worship.
- C. Public-office-as-trust is an ethical fiduciary analogy: officials hold authority for citizens and public purpose. The settled Indian environmental public-trust doctrine concerns State trusteeship of certain natural resources and does not directly govern every public-office decision.
- D. Gandhian trusteeship treats possession and power as stewardship for social welfare, while the unity of means and ends rejects corrupt methods for desirable outcomes; applied to governance, both ideas support public-purpose administration without converting analogy into positive law.

Answer: D

Explanation: Gandhian trusteeship joins means, ends and stewardship is the controlling principle. Gandhian trusteeship treats possession and power as stewardship for social welfare, while the unity of means and ends rejects corrupt methods for desirable outcomes; applied to governance, both ideas support public-purpose administration without converting analogy into positive law. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 25

A popular majority demands exclusion of a minority from a public hearing, but the officer protects equal participation. Which moral framework guides the decision? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Constitutional morality requires fidelity to constitutional values, procedures and restraints rather than personal preference or temporary majority pressure; civil education, institutional practice, reasoned decisions and lawful review help sustain it.
- B. Procedural probity asks whether authority, notice, equal information, objective criteria, recorded reasons, conflict controls, audit trails and review were properly built into the decision-making process.
- C. Substantive probity asks whether the decision and its real effects serve the authorised public purpose, respect equal citizenship and avoid disguised private capture; impeccable paperwork cannot legitimise an outcome engineered for a narrow interest.
- D. Transparency supports probity when material criteria, interests, reasons and records are accessible to appropriate scrutiny; written reasons discipline discretion, enable audit and appeal, and must still respect lawful privacy and confidentiality.

Answer: A

Explanation: Constitutional morality restrains power through constitutional values is the controlling principle. Constitutional morality requires fidelity to constitutional values, procedures and restraints rather than personal preference or temporary majority pressure; civil education, institutional practice, reasoned decisions and lawful review help sustain it. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 26

A public servant invokes personal ideology while ignoring equality, due process and institutional competence. Which standard corrects this misuse of moral language? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Substantive probity asks whether the decision and its real effects serve the authorised public purpose, respect equal citizenship and avoid disguised private capture; impeccable paperwork cannot legitimise an outcome engineered for a narrow interest.
- B. Constitutional morality requires fidelity to constitutional values, procedures and restraints rather than personal preference or temporary majority pressure; civil education, institutional practice, reasoned decisions and lawful review help sustain it.
- C. Transparency supports probity when material criteria, interests, reasons and records are accessible to appropriate scrutiny; written reasons discipline discretion, enable audit and appeal, and must still respect lawful privacy and confidentiality.
- D. Procedural probity asks whether authority, notice, equal information, objective criteria, recorded reasons, conflict controls, audit trails and review were properly built into the decision-making process.

Answer: B

Explanation: Constitutional morality restrains power through constitutional values is the controlling principle. Constitutional morality requires fidelity to constitutional values, procedures and restraints rather than personal preference or temporary majority pressure; civil education, institutional practice, reasoned decisions and lawful review help sustain it. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 27

Every bidder receives identical information, evaluators declare interests and scoring reasons are preserved. Which dimension of probity is most directly demonstrated? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Constitutional morality requires fidelity to constitutional values, procedures and restraints rather than personal preference or temporary majority pressure; civil education, institutional practice, reasoned decisions and lawful review help sustain it.
- B. Substantive probity asks whether the decision and its real effects serve the authorised public purpose, respect equal citizenship and avoid disguised private capture; impeccable paperwork cannot legitimise an outcome engineered for a narrow interest.
- C. Procedural probity asks whether authority, notice, equal information, objective criteria, recorded reasons, conflict controls, audit trails and review were properly built into the decision-making process.
- D. Transparency supports probity when material criteria, interests, reasons and records are accessible to appropriate scrutiny; written reasons discipline discretion, enable audit and appeal, and must still respect lawful privacy and confidentiality.

Answer: C

Explanation: Procedural probity makes decisions traceable and fair is the controlling principle. Procedural probity asks whether authority, notice, equal information, objective criteria, recorded reasons, conflict controls, audit trails and review were properly built into the decision-making process. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 28

A beneficiary receives a useful outcome through secret criteria and an undocumented oral order. Which dimension remains deficient despite the benefit? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Substantive probity asks whether the decision and its real effects serve the authorised public purpose, respect equal citizenship and avoid disguised private capture; impeccable paperwork cannot legitimise an outcome engineered for a narrow interest.
- B. Transparency supports probity when material criteria, interests, reasons and records are accessible to appropriate scrutiny; written reasons discipline discretion, enable audit and appeal, and must still respect lawful privacy and confidentiality.
- C. Constitutional morality requires fidelity to constitutional values, procedures and restraints rather than personal preference or temporary majority pressure; civil education, institutional practice, reasoned decisions and lawful review help sustain it.
- D. Procedural probity asks whether authority, notice, equal information, objective criteria, recorded reasons, conflict controls, audit trails and review were properly built into the decision-making process.

Answer: D

Explanation: Procedural probity makes decisions traceable and fair is the controlling principle. Procedural probity asks whether authority, notice, equal information, objective criteria, recorded reasons, conflict controls, audit trails and review were properly built into the decision-making process. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 29

A tender follows every form but its specifications were designed to favour one connected vendor without public need. Which probity test exposes the defect? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Substantive probity asks whether the decision and its real effects serve the authorised public purpose, respect equal citizenship and avoid disguised private capture; impeccable paperwork cannot legitimise an outcome engineered for a narrow interest.
- B. Constitutional morality requires fidelity to constitutional values, procedures and restraints rather than personal preference or temporary majority pressure; civil education, institutional practice, reasoned decisions and lawful review help sustain it.
- C. Procedural probity asks whether authority, notice, equal information, objective criteria, recorded reasons, conflict controls, audit trails and review were properly built into the decision-making process.
- D. Transparency supports probity when material criteria, interests, reasons and records are accessible to appropriate scrutiny; written reasons discipline discretion, enable audit and appeal, and must still respect lawful privacy and confidentiality.

Answer: A

Explanation: Substantive probity tests the authorised public purpose is the controlling principle. Substantive probity asks whether the decision and its real effects serve the authorised public purpose, respect equal citizenship and avoid disguised private capture; impeccable paperwork cannot legitimise an outcome engineered for a narrow interest. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 30

An emergency action saves lives but initially misses a minor formality that is promptly cured. Which dimension explains why purpose matters alongside procedure? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Procedural probity asks whether authority, notice, equal information, objective criteria, recorded reasons, conflict controls, audit trails and review were properly built into the decision-making process.
- B. Substantive probity asks whether the decision and its real effects serve the authorised public purpose, respect equal citizenship and avoid disguised private capture; impeccable paperwork cannot legitimise an outcome engineered for a narrow interest.
- C. Transparency supports probity when material criteria, interests, reasons and records are accessible to appropriate scrutiny; written reasons discipline discretion, enable audit and appeal, and must still respect lawful privacy and confidentiality.
- D. Constitutional morality requires fidelity to constitutional values, procedures and restraints rather than personal preference or temporary majority pressure; civil education, institutional practice, reasoned decisions and lawful review help sustain it.

Answer: B

Explanation: Substantive probity tests the authorised public purpose is the controlling principle. Substantive probity asks whether the decision and its real effects serve the authorised public purpose, respect equal citizenship and avoid disguised private capture; impeccable paperwork cannot legitimise an outcome engineered for a narrow interest. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 31

A licensing authority announces the result but conceals the criteria and gives no reasons. Which probity-enabling transparency feature is missing? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Constitutional morality requires fidelity to constitutional values, procedures and restraints rather than personal preference or temporary majority pressure; civil education, institutional practice, reasoned decisions and lawful review help sustain it.
- B. Procedural probity asks whether authority, notice, equal information, objective criteria, recorded reasons, conflict controls, audit trails and review were properly built into the decision-making process.
- C. Transparency supports probity when material criteria, interests, reasons and records are accessible to appropriate scrutiny; written reasons discipline discretion, enable audit and appeal, and must still respect lawful privacy and confidentiality.
- D. Substantive probity asks whether the decision and its real effects serve the authorised public purpose, respect equal citizenship and avoid disguised private capture; impeccable paperwork cannot legitimise an outcome engineered for a narrow interest.

Answer: C

Explanation: Transparency needs written reasons and a usable record is the controlling principle. Transparency supports probity when material criteria, interests, reasons and records are accessible to appropriate scrutiny; written reasons discipline discretion, enable audit and appeal, and must still respect lawful privacy and confidentiality. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 32

A file records the evidence, alternatives and reasons while redacting protected personal data. Which balanced transparency design is illustrated? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Procedural probity asks whether authority, notice, equal information, objective criteria, recorded reasons, conflict controls, audit trails and review were properly built into the decision-making process.
- B. Substantive probity asks whether the decision and its real effects serve the authorised public purpose, respect equal citizenship and avoid disguised private capture; impeccable paperwork cannot legitimise an outcome engineered for a narrow interest.
- C. Constitutional morality requires fidelity to constitutional values, procedures and restraints rather than personal preference or temporary majority pressure; civil education, institutional practice, reasoned decisions and lawful review help sustain it.
- D. Transparency supports probity when material criteria, interests, reasons and records are accessible to appropriate scrutiny; written reasons discipline discretion, enable audit and appeal, and must still respect lawful privacy and confidentiality.

Answer: D

Explanation: Transparency needs written reasons and a usable record is the controlling principle. Transparency supports probity when material criteria, interests, reasons and records are accessible to appropriate scrutiny; written reasons discipline discretion, enable audit and appeal, and must still respect lawful privacy and confidentiality. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 33

A procurement chair's sibling submits a bid and the chair promises privately to remain neutral. Which safeguard should ordinarily follow disclosure? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A material conflict of interest requires timely disclosure and, where impartiality or its appearance would reasonably be compromised, recusal or independent reassignment; private assurances of fairness are not an adequate institutional safeguard.
- B. A code of ethics states public-service values and decision principles, whereas a code of conduct specifies expected or prohibited behaviour, procedures and consequences; credible implementation requires advice, training, monitoring, fair inquiry and leadership.
- C. RPA s.75A requires an elected candidate to a House of Parliament to declare assets and liabilities within ninety days of oath; CCS Rule 18 and AIS Rule 16 create separate service-rule annual property-return regimes, while current Lokpal s.44 uses substituted prescribed-form wording.
- D. Departmental and CAG audit examine records, legality, regularity and performance within their mandates; CVC exercises vigilance oversight and CVOs coordinate departmental vigilance, while social audit enables citizens to compare official claims with lived delivery and demand follow-up.

Answer: A

Explanation: Material conflicts normally require disclosure and recusal is the controlling principle. A material conflict of interest requires timely disclosure and, where impartiality or its appearance would reasonably be compromised, recusal or independent reassignment; private assurances of fairness are not an adequate institutional safeguard. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 34

An official has a remote immaterial acquaintance with an applicant. Which principle calls for a proportionate conflict assessment rather than automatic paralysis? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. RPA s.75A requires an elected candidate to a House of Parliament to declare assets and liabilities within ninety days of oath; CCS Rule 18 and AIS Rule 16 create separate service-rule annual property-return regimes, while current Lokpal s.44 uses substituted prescribed-form wording.
- B. A material conflict of interest requires timely disclosure and, where impartiality or its appearance would reasonably be compromised, recusal or independent reassignment; private assurances of fairness are not an adequate institutional safeguard.
- C. Departmental and CAG audit examine records, legality, regularity and performance within their mandates; CVC exercises vigilance oversight and CVOs coordinate departmental vigilance, while social audit enables citizens to compare official claims with lived delivery and demand follow-up.
- D. A code of ethics states public-service values and decision principles, whereas a code of conduct specifies expected or prohibited behaviour, procedures and consequences; credible implementation requires advice, training, monitoring, fair inquiry and leadership.

Answer: B

Explanation: Material conflicts normally require disclosure and recusal is the controlling principle. A material conflict of interest requires timely disclosure and, where impartiality or its appearance would reasonably be compromised, recusal or independent reassignment; private assurances of fairness are not an adequate institutional safeguard. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 35

A department publishes selflessness and impartiality but gives no guidance for gifts, recusals or complaints. Which code distinction identifies the missing layer? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A material conflict of interest requires timely disclosure and, where impartiality or its appearance would reasonably be compromised, recusal or independent reassignment; private assurances of fairness are not an adequate institutional safeguard.
- B. RPA s.75A requires an elected candidate to a House of Parliament to declare assets and liabilities within ninety days of oath; CCS Rule 18 and AIS Rule 16 create separate service-rule annual property-return regimes, while current Lokpal s.44 uses substituted prescribed-form wording.
- C. A code of ethics states public-service values and decision principles, whereas a code of conduct specifies expected or prohibited behaviour, procedures and consequences; credible implementation requires advice, training, monitoring, fair inquiry and leadership.
- D. Departmental and CAG audit examine records, legality, regularity and performance within their mandates; CVC exercises vigilance oversight and CVOs coordinate departmental vigilance, while social audit enables citizens to compare official claims with lived delivery and demand follow-up.

Answer: C

Explanation: Codes of ethics and conduct perform different functions is the controlling principle. A code of ethics states public-service values and decision principles, whereas a code of conduct specifies expected or prohibited behaviour, procedures and consequences; credible implementation requires advice, training, monitoring, fair inquiry and leadership. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 36

A service rule lists gift limits and disciplinary consequences but never explains constitutional public-purpose values. Which complementary instrument is needed? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. RPA s.75A requires an elected candidate to a House of Parliament to declare assets and liabilities within ninety days of oath; CCS Rule 18 and AIS Rule 16 create separate service-rule annual property-return regimes, while current Lokpal s.44 uses substituted prescribed-form wording.
- B. Departmental and CAG audit examine records, legality, regularity and performance within their mandates; CVC exercises vigilance oversight and CVOs coordinate departmental vigilance, while social audit enables citizens to compare official claims with lived delivery and demand follow-up.
- C. A material conflict of interest requires timely disclosure and, where impartiality or its appearance would reasonably be compromised, recusal or independent reassignment; private assurances of fairness are not an adequate institutional safeguard.
- D. A code of ethics states public-service values and decision principles, whereas a code of conduct specifies expected or prohibited behaviour, procedures and consequences; credible implementation requires advice, training, monitoring, fair inquiry and leadership.

Answer: D

Explanation: Codes of ethics and conduct perform different functions is the controlling principle. A code of ethics states public-service values and decision principles, whereas a code of conduct specifies expected or prohibited behaviour, procedures and consequences; credible implementation requires advice, training, monitoring, fair inquiry and leadership. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 37

A note describes RPA section 75A as an annual return for every legislator and civil servant. Which statutory distinction corrects it? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. RPA s.75A requires an elected candidate to a House of Parliament to declare assets and liabilities within ninety days of oath; CCS Rule 18 and AIS Rule 16 create separate service-rule annual property-return regimes, while current Lokpal s.44 uses substituted prescribed-form wording.
- B. A material conflict of interest requires timely disclosure and, where impartiality or its appearance would reasonably be compromised, recusal or independent reassignment; private assurances of fairness are not an adequate institutional safeguard.
- C. A code of ethics states public-service values and decision principles, whereas a code of conduct specifies expected or prohibited behaviour, procedures and consequences; credible implementation requires advice, training, monitoring, fair inquiry and leadership.
- D. Departmental and CAG audit examine records, legality, regularity and performance within their mandates; CVC exercises vigilance oversight and CVOs coordinate departmental vigilance, while social audit enables citizens to compare official claims with lived delivery and demand follow-up.

Answer: A

Explanation: Indian asset-disclosure regimes must not be conflated is the controlling principle. RPA s.75A requires an elected candidate to a House of Parliament to declare assets and liabilities within ninety days of oath; CCS Rule 18 and AIS Rule 16 create separate service-rule annual property-return regimes, while current Lokpal s.44 uses substituted prescribed-form wording. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 38

An answer claims current Lokpal section 44 itself mandates universal online publication under its earlier elaborate text. Which amendment-sensitive caution applies? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A code of ethics states public-service values and decision principles, whereas a code of conduct specifies expected or prohibited behaviour, procedures and consequences; credible implementation requires advice, training, monitoring, fair inquiry and leadership.
- B. RPA s.75A requires an elected candidate to a House of Parliament to declare assets and liabilities within ninety days of oath; CCS Rule 18 and AIS Rule 16 create separate service-rule annual property-return regimes, while current Lokpal s.44 uses substituted prescribed-form wording.
- C. Departmental and CAG audit examine records, legality, regularity and performance within their mandates; CVC exercises vigilance oversight and CVOs coordinate departmental vigilance, while social audit enables citizens to compare official claims with lived delivery and demand follow-up.
- D. A material conflict of interest requires timely disclosure and, where impartiality or its appearance would reasonably be compromised, recusal or independent reassignment; private assurances of fairness are not an adequate institutional safeguard.

Answer: B

Explanation: Indian asset-disclosure regimes must not be conflated is the controlling principle. RPA s.75A requires an elected candidate to a House of Parliament to declare assets and liabilities within ninety days of oath; CCS Rule 18 and AIS Rule 16 create separate service-rule annual property-return regimes, while current Lokpal s.44 uses substituted prescribed-form wording. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 39

Workers compare muster rolls with actual employment at a public hearing, while financial auditors examine accounts separately. Which institutional distinction is illustrated? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A material conflict of interest requires timely disclosure and, where impartiality or its appearance would reasonably be compromised, recusal or independent reassignment; private assurances of fairness are not an adequate institutional safeguard.
- B. A code of ethics states public-service values and decision principles, whereas a code of conduct specifies expected or prohibited behaviour, procedures and consequences; credible implementation requires advice, training, monitoring, fair inquiry and leadership.
- C. Departmental and CAG audit examine records, legality, regularity and performance within their mandates; CVC exercises vigilance oversight and CVOs coordinate departmental vigilance, while social audit enables citizens to compare official claims with lived delivery and demand follow-up.
- D. RPA s.75A requires an elected candidate to a House of Parliament to declare assets and liabilities within ninety days of oath; CCS Rule 18 and AIS Rule 16 create separate service-rule annual property-return regimes, while current Lokpal s.44 uses substituted prescribed-form wording.

Answer: C

Explanation: Audit and vigilance bodies have distinct roles is the controlling principle. Departmental and CAG audit examine records, legality, regularity and performance within their mandates; CVC exercises vigilance oversight and CVOs coordinate departmental vigilance, while social audit enables citizens to compare official claims with lived delivery and demand follow-up. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 40

A department asks its CVO to replace statutory audit, citizen verification and adjudicatory remedy. Which role-boundary principle rejects this consolidation? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A code of ethics states public-service values and decision principles, whereas a code of conduct specifies expected or prohibited behaviour, procedures and consequences; credible implementation requires advice, training, monitoring, fair inquiry and leadership.
- B. RPA s.75A requires an elected candidate to a House of Parliament to declare assets and liabilities within ninety days of oath; CCS Rule 18 and AIS Rule 16 create separate service-rule annual property-return regimes, while current Lokpal s.44 uses substituted prescribed-form wording.
- C. A material conflict of interest requires timely disclosure and, where impartiality or its appearance would reasonably be compromised, recusal or independent reassignment; private assurances of fairness are not an adequate institutional safeguard.
- D. Departmental and CAG audit examine records, legality, regularity and performance within their mandates; CVC exercises vigilance oversight and CVOs coordinate departmental vigilance, while social audit enables citizens to compare official claims with lived delivery and demand follow-up.

Answer: D

Explanation: Audit and vigilance bodies have distinct roles is the controlling principle. Departmental and CAG audit examine records, legality, regularity and performance within their mandates; CVC exercises vigilance oversight and CVOs coordinate departmental vigilance, while social audit enables citizens to compare official claims with lived delivery and demand follow-up. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 41

A government is transparent but systematically excludes affected communities and ignores legal limits. Which wider good-governance framework shows why transparency alone is insufficient? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The UNESCAP formulation cited by the ARC describes good governance as participatory, consensus oriented, accountable, transparent, responsive, effective and efficient, equitable and inclusive, and following the rule of law.
- B. Risk-graded scrutiny applies lighter documentation to routine low-value decisions and stronger ex-ante disclosure, competition, reasons and review to high-value, high-discretion or high-harm decisions, avoiding both uniform suspicion and blind trust.
- C. A sound probity regime protects documented bona-fide judgment and honest risk-taking while preserving independent review, correction and remedy for affected persons; protection from hindsight punishment is not immunity from reasons, evidence or accountability.
- D. A GeM bid may incorporate an Integrity Pact committing buyer and sellers against corrupt influence, collusion and misuse of electronic information while requiring equitable treatment and vigilance reporting; its contractual force depends on incorporation in the particular procurement.

Answer: A

Explanation: UNESCAP identifies eight characteristics of good governance is the controlling principle. The UNESCAP formulation cited by the ARC describes good governance as participatory, consensus oriented, accountable, transparent, responsive, effective and efficient, equitable and inclusive, and following the rule of law. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 42

A prelims option replaces responsiveness with secrecy while retaining seven familiar terms. Which exact eight-characteristic formulation resolves the trap? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A sound probity regime protects documented bona-fide judgment and honest risk-taking while preserving independent review, correction and remedy for affected persons; protection from hindsight punishment is not immunity from reasons, evidence or accountability.
- B. The UNESCAP formulation cited by the ARC describes good governance as participatory, consensus oriented, accountable, transparent, responsive, effective and efficient, equitable and inclusive, and following the rule of law.
- C. A GeM bid may incorporate an Integrity Pact committing buyer and sellers against corrupt influence, collusion and misuse of electronic information while requiring equitable treatment and vigilance reporting; its contractual force depends on incorporation in the particular procurement.
- D. Risk-graded scrutiny applies lighter documentation to routine low-value decisions and stronger ex-ante disclosure, competition, reasons and review to high-value, high-discretion or high-harm decisions, avoiding both uniform suspicion and blind trust.

Answer: B

Explanation: UNESCAP identifies eight characteristics of good governance is the controlling principle. The UNESCAP formulation cited by the ARC describes good governance as participatory, consensus oriented, accountable, transparent, responsive, effective and efficient, equitable and inclusive, and following the rule of law. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 43

A department requires fifty approvals for every minor stationery purchase but little review of land allotment. Which design principle would reverse the mismatch? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The UNESCAP formulation cited by the ARC describes good governance as participatory, consensus oriented, accountable, transparent, responsive, effective and efficient, equitable and inclusive, and following the rule of law.
- B. A sound probity regime protects documented bona-fide judgment and honest risk-taking while preserving independent review, correction and remedy for affected persons; protection from hindsight punishment is not immunity from reasons, evidence or accountability.
- C. Risk-graded scrutiny applies lighter documentation to routine low-value decisions and stronger ex-ante disclosure, competition, reasons and review to high-value, high-discretion or high-harm decisions, avoiding both uniform suspicion and blind trust.
- D. A GeM bid may incorporate an Integrity Pact committing buyer and sellers against corrupt influence, collusion and misuse of electronic information while requiring equitable treatment and vigilance reporting; its contractual force depends on incorporation in the particular procurement.

Answer: C

Explanation: Scrutiny should be graded by value, discretion and harm is the controlling principle. Risk-graded scrutiny applies lighter documentation to routine low-value decisions and stronger ex-ante disclosure, competition, reasons and review to high-value, high-discretion or high-harm decisions, avoiding both uniform suspicion and blind trust. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 44

A high-value specialised procurement carries narrow competition and major safety consequences. Which scrutiny approach is proportionate? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A sound probity regime protects documented bona-fide judgment and honest risk-taking while preserving independent review, correction and remedy for affected persons; protection from hindsight punishment is not immunity from reasons, evidence or accountability.
- B. A GeM bid may incorporate an Integrity Pact committing buyer and sellers against corrupt influence, collusion and misuse of electronic information while requiring equitable treatment and vigilance reporting; its contractual force depends on incorporation in the particular procurement.
- C. The UNESCAP formulation cited by the ARC describes good governance as participatory, consensus oriented, accountable, transparent, responsive, effective and efficient, equitable and inclusive, and following the rule of law.
- D. Risk-graded scrutiny applies lighter documentation to routine low-value decisions and stronger ex-ante disclosure, competition, reasons and review to high-value, high-discretion or high-harm decisions, avoiding both uniform suspicion and blind trust.

Answer: D

Explanation: Scrutiny should be graded by value, discretion and harm is the controlling principle. Risk-graded scrutiny applies lighter documentation to routine low-value decisions and stronger ex-ante disclosure, competition, reasons and review to high-value, high-discretion or high-harm decisions, avoiding both uniform suspicion and blind trust. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 45

An officer makes a reasoned emergency choice on incomplete information and later faces automatic punishment solely because the outcome was poor. Which safeguard applies? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. A sound probity regime protects documented bona-fide judgment and honest risk-taking while preserving independent review, correction and remedy for affected persons; protection from hindsight punishment is not immunity from reasons, evidence or accountability.
- B. The UNESCAP formulation cited by the ARC describes good governance as participatory, consensus oriented, accountable, transparent, responsive, effective and efficient, equitable and inclusive, and following the rule of law.
- C. Risk-graded scrutiny applies lighter documentation to routine low-value decisions and stronger ex-ante disclosure, competition, reasons and review to high-value, high-discretion or high-harm decisions, avoiding both uniform suspicion and blind trust.
- D. A GeM bid may incorporate an Integrity Pact committing buyer and sellers against corrupt influence, collusion and misuse of electronic information while requiring equitable treatment and vigilance reporting; its contractual force depends on incorporation in the particular procurement.

Answer: A

Explanation: Bona-fide action needs protection, review and remedy is the controlling principle. A sound probity regime protects documented bona-fide judgment and honest risk-taking while preserving independent review, correction and remedy for affected persons; protection from hindsight punishment is not immunity from reasons, evidence or accountability. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 46

A good-faith clause is invoked to block every appeal and deny compensation for proven harm. Which accountability qualification defeats that use? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Risk-graded scrutiny applies lighter documentation to routine low-value decisions and stronger ex-ante disclosure, competition, reasons and review to high-value, high-discretion or high-harm decisions, avoiding both uniform suspicion and blind trust.
- B. A sound probity regime protects documented bona-fide judgment and honest risk-taking while preserving independent review, correction and remedy for affected persons; protection from hindsight punishment is not immunity from reasons, evidence or accountability.
- C. A GeM bid may incorporate an Integrity Pact committing buyer and sellers against corrupt influence, collusion and misuse of electronic information while requiring equitable treatment and vigilance reporting; its contractual force depends on incorporation in the particular procurement.
- D. The UNESCAP formulation cited by the ARC describes good governance as participatory, consensus oriented, accountable, transparent, responsive, effective and efficient, equitable and inclusive, and following the rule of law.

Answer: B

Explanation: Bona-fide action needs protection, review and remedy is the controlling principle. A sound probity regime protects documented bona-fide judgment and honest risk-taking while preserving independent review, correction and remedy for affected persons; protection from hindsight punishment is not immunity from reasons, evidence or accountability. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 47

Bid document 9511605 requires bidders to upload a signed buyer-organisation Integrity Pact. Which ex-ante probity mechanism is illustrated? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. The UNESCAP formulation cited by the ARC describes good governance as participatory, consensus oriented, accountable, transparent, responsive, effective and efficient, equitable and inclusive, and following the rule of law.
- B. Risk-graded scrutiny applies lighter documentation to routine low-value decisions and stronger ex-ante disclosure, competition, reasons and review to high-value, high-discretion or high-harm decisions, avoiding both uniform suspicion and blind trust.
- C. A GeM bid may incorporate an Integrity Pact committing buyer and sellers against corrupt influence, collusion and misuse of electronic information while requiring equitable treatment and vigilance reporting; its contractual force depends on incorporation in the particular procurement.
- D. A sound probity regime protects documented bona-fide judgment and honest risk-taking while preserving independent review, correction and remedy for affected persons; protection from hindsight punishment is not immunity from reasons, evidence or accountability.

Answer: C

Explanation: A GeM Integrity Pact is an incorporated procurement control is the controlling principle. A GeM bid may incorporate an Integrity Pact committing buyer and sellers against corrupt influence, collusion and misuse of electronic information while requiring equitable treatment and vigilance reporting; its contractual force depends on incorporation in the particular procurement. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

MCQ 48

An investigator treats the Pact as automatic proof of criminal guilt and a substitute for competition review. Which limitation applies? Which source-grounded ethical principle most precisely explains the case?

- A. Risk-graded scrutiny applies lighter documentation to routine low-value decisions and stronger ex-ante disclosure, competition, reasons and review to high-value, high-discretion or high-harm decisions, avoiding both uniform suspicion and blind trust.
- B. A sound probity regime protects documented bona-fide judgment and honest risk-taking while preserving independent review, correction and remedy for affected persons; protection from hindsight punishment is not immunity from reasons, evidence or accountability.
- C. The UNESCAP formulation cited by the ARC describes good governance as participatory, consensus oriented, accountable, transparent, responsive, effective and efficient, equitable and inclusive, and following the rule of law.
- D. A GeM bid may incorporate an Integrity Pact committing buyer and sellers against corrupt influence, collusion and misuse of electronic information while requiring equitable treatment and vigilance reporting; its contractual force depends on incorporation in the particular procurement.

Answer: D

Explanation: A GeM Integrity Pact is an incorporated procurement control is the controlling principle. A GeM bid may incorporate an Integrity Pact committing buyer and sellers against corrupt influence, collusion and misuse of electronic information while requiring equitable treatment and vigilance reporting; its contractual force depends on incorporation in the particular procurement. The distractors are related propositions, but they do not identify the decisive mechanism in this case.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

Solved PYQ 1 - 2018 - 20 marks

Question: GS-IV Q11: Dr. X is a leading medical practitioner in a city. He has set up a charitable trust through which he plans to establish a super-speciality hospital in the city to cater to the medical needs of all sections of the society. Incidentally, that part of the State had been neglected over the years. The proposed hospital would be a boon for the region.

You are heading the tax investigation agency of that region. During an inspection of the doctor's clinic, your officers have found out some major irregularities. A few of them are substantial which had resulted in considerable withholding of tax that should be paid by him now. The doctor is cooperative. He undertakes to pay the tax immediately.

However, there are certain other deficiencies in his tax compliance which are purely technical in nature. If these technical defaults are pursued by the agency, considerable time and energy of the doctor will be diverted to issues which are not so serious, urgent or even helpful to the tax collection process. Further, in all probability, it will hamper the prospects of the hospital coming up.

There are two options before you: (i) Taking a broader view, ensure substantial tax compliance and ignore defaults that are merely technical in nature. (ii) Pursue the matter strictly and proceed on all fronts, whether substantial or merely technical. As the head of the tax agency, which course of action will you opt for and why? (Answer in 250 words)

Source / ownership: Exact full case, facts and both options verified against books\more_previous_papers\GENERAL-STUDIES-PAPER-IV.pdf, page 10. Topic 14 supplies probity, propriety and proportionality; Topic 22 supplies the case-study architecture.

Model solution

Stakeholders are taxpayers, Dr. X, patients in a neglected region, the charitable trust, honest assesseees, tax officials and the credibility of revenue administration. The competing values are legality, equality, revenue collection and deterrence on one side, and proportionality, administrative economy, public health and facilitation of a beneficial hospital on the other.

Option (i) correctly prioritises substantial compliance but cannot mean informal waiver. Ignoring technical defaults without statutory authority may create unequal treatment, precedent and suspicion of favouritism. Option (ii) displays formal consistency, yet mechanically pursuing harmless defects may waste public resources and frustrate the law's revenue purpose without proportionate gain.

I would adopt a reasoned, lawful version of the broader course. The agency should quantify and recover the withheld tax, interest and any legally warranted consequence after due process. Technical defaults should be classified: cure remediable defects within a written deadline; use statutory compounding, warning or minimal penalty where available; pursue any defect that conceals income, obstructs audit or affects third-party rights. The hospital proposal must not buy immunity, and the doctor should receive no treatment unavailable to a similarly placed taxpayer.

I would record reasons, obtain competent legal approval, preserve an audit trail and separate the tax order from any decision concerning the charitable trust. A review route should remain open. This course joins procedural probity with substantive public purpose: it collects lawful revenue and protects equality while avoiding mindless formality. If the statute mandates action on a particular default, the agency must comply; discretion permits proportionality, not suspension of law.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 2 - 2019 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q3(a): What is meant by the term 'constitutional morality'? How does one uphold constitutional morality? (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact isolated subpart verified against books\more_previous_papers\QP-CSM19-GeneralStudies-IV.pdf, page 2. Crisis of conscience in Q3(b) is excluded; Topic 10 remains a cross-link.

Model solution

Constitutional morality is fidelity to the Constitution's values, procedures and restraints on public power, rather than obedience to personal preference or a temporary majority. It requires liberty, equality, dignity, due process, institutional competence and non-arbitrariness to guide public action.

It is upheld through civil education and repeated institutional practice: acting within lawful authority; giving affected persons notice and hearing; treating like cases alike; recording intelligible reasons; protecting minority participation; respecting checks and judicial review; and correcting decisions that fail constitutional standards. For example, a district officer should resist popular pressure to exclude a minority group from a public consultation and should preserve equal access through a reasoned order.

Constitutional morality does not authorise an official to replace valid law with private ideology. It disciplines both majoritarian power and bureaucratic discretion through public reasons, lawful process and review. Thus it turns public office from personal command into accountable constitutional service.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 3 - 2019 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q5(a): What do you understand by probity in governance? Based on your understanding of the term, suggest measures for ensuring probity in government. (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact isolated subpart verified against books\more_previous_papers\QP-CSM19-GeneralStudies-IV.pdf, page 3. Emotional intelligence in Q5(b) is excluded.

Model solution

Probity in governance is upright, impartial and public-purpose conduct in entrusted office, made capable of public justification and appropriate verification. It draws on honesty, integrity and propriety but is not a rigid synonym or hierarchy; it asks whether power was exercised for authorised purposes through a fair and reviewable process.

Measures should combine character and institutions: values-based recruitment and training; clear codes of ethics and conduct; timely conflict disclosure and recusal; transparent criteria and written reasons; e-procurement and tamper-evident records; proportionate asset declarations; independent departmental and CAG audit; effective CVC-CVO vigilance; RTI-compatible proactive disclosure; social audit where citizens can verify delivery; protected good-faith reporting; time-bound inquiry, appeal and remedy.

Scrutiny should be risk-graded, strongest for high-value or high-discretion decisions, while documented bona-fide judgment receives protection from hindsight punishment. Probity is therefore neither private virtue alone nor paper compliance: it is ethical public purpose translated into traceable, contestable and correctable administration.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 4 - 2021 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q6(a): An independent and empowered social audit mechanism is an absolute must in every sphere of public service, including judiciary, to ensure performance, accountability and ethical conduct. Elaborate. (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact isolated subpart verified against books\more_previous_papers\QP-CSM-21-GENSTUDIESPAPER-IV-110122.pdf, page 3. Topic 11 is the primary accountability owner; this is a probity cross-link.

Model solution

Social audit converts citizens from passive recipients into participants who compare official records with lived outcomes. Independence from the implementing body, proactive access to records, beneficiary verification and a public hearing can expose exclusion, ghost entries, weak performance and ethical failure hidden by files.

Empowerment requires follow-up: a time-bound action-taken report, correction or compensation, recovery or disciplinary referral where evidence supports it, reasoned rejection of unsupported allegations and protection against intimidation. In MGNREGA, workers can compare job cards, muster rolls, wages and physical works.

The phrase 'every sphere' needs functional adaptation. Judicial accountability cannot permit a crowd to dictate adjudication; confidentiality, decisional independence and lawful appellate or disciplinary structures must remain. Social audit complements, rather than replaces, CAG or departmental audit, vigilance, courts and statutory remedies. Its probity contribution is public verifiability joined to competent correction; disclosure without response is transparency, not complete accountability.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 5 - 2021 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q6(b): 'Integrity is a value that empowers the human being.' Justify with suitable illustration. (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact isolated subpart verified against books\more_previous_papers\QP-CSM-21-GENSTUDIESPAPER-IV-110122.pdf, page 3. Topic 07/09 is primary; Topic 14 uses it to distinguish integrity from probity.

Model solution

Integrity empowers because consistency between principle, word and action reduces inner fragmentation and dependence on improper influence. A person who has settled ethical commitments can decide with courage, earn trust and cooperate without the continuing fear that concealed compromise will be exposed.

For example, a procurement officer offered political protection for favouring a bidder can disclose the approach, apply published criteria and seek independent review. Integrity enables resistance because career convenience no longer determines the decision. Institutional safeguards still matter: secure reporting, written directions and fair inquiry convert personal courage into sustainable action.

Integrity should not be collapsed into probity. Integrity is principled consistency and independence from improper influence; probity is the public-office standard that also asks whether entrusted power is demonstrably upright, impartial, public-purpose and reviewable. Nor is honesty merely a subset of integrity. These values overlap, but their functional distinctions help explain how character empowers the person while institutions protect the public.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 6 - 2022 - 2 marks

Question: GS-IV Q5(b)(iii): Write a short note in 30 words: Probity in public life. (Official demand: 2 marks and 30 words.)

Source / ownership: Exact isolated short-note demand verified against books\more_previous_papers\QP-CSM-22-GENERAL-STUDIES-PAPER IV-190922.pdf, page 4. This model is deliberately expanded beyond the official 30-word demand to satisfy the current learner-v2 minimum-answer contract; it is for learning, not an exam-length prescription.

Model solution

Exam-ready 30-word core: Probity in public life is upright, impartial and public-purpose use of entrusted power, demonstrated through transparent reasons, conflict control, audit, answerability and effective remedy.

Learning expansion: The definition combines ethical character with institutional verification. Honesty asks whether the official is truthful; integrity asks whether principle survives pressure; propriety asks whether conduct is appropriate to office; accountability asks whether a competent forum can examine and correct it. Probity brings these overlapping tests to the exercise of public power without turning them into a rigid hierarchy.

Practical mechanisms include declared interests, recusal, written reasons, fair procurement, asset returns, audit trails, RTI-compatible disclosure and review. Yet paperwork alone is insufficient: a formally perfect decision designed for private capture fails substantive probity. In the examination, compress the first sentence to the official thirty-word demand; the longer treatment here exists only for conceptual mastery.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 7 - 2023 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q5(b): 'Probity is essential for an effective system of governance and socio-economic development.' Discuss. (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact isolated subpart verified against books\more_previous_papers\QP-CSM-23-GENERAL-STUDIES-PAPER-IV-180923.pdf, page 4. Conscience in Q5(a) is excluded.

Model solution

Probity makes public power upright, impartial, public-purpose and reviewable. It improves governance because written reasons, fair competition, conflict control and audit reduce arbitrary discretion, leakage and policy capture. Citizens and firms can plan when like cases receive like treatment, while officials gain a defensible record for bona-fide decisions.

The development link is causal. Clean procurement yields more infrastructure from each rupee; transparent beneficiary selection improves inclusion; reliable regulation encourages investment; and correction mechanisms protect citizens from exclusion. Conversely, corruption and opaque discretion divert resources, raise transaction costs and distribute opportunity by connection rather than need or merit.

Probity is necessary but not sufficient. UNESCAP's wider framework also requires participation, responsiveness, effectiveness, equity and rule of law. Excessive uniform scrutiny can delay legitimate action, so controls should be risk-graded and protect documented good faith while retaining review and remedy. Development becomes durable when ethical public purpose is supported by capable institutions, not moral exhortation alone.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 8 - 2024 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q5(a): The 'Code of Conduct' and 'Code of Ethics' are the sources of guidance in public administration. There is code of conduct already in operation, whereas code of ethics is not yet put in place. Suggest a suitable model for code of ethics to maintain integrity, probity and transparency in governance. (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact isolated subpart verified against books\mains\05 UPSC 2024 Paper-IV_Final 1.pdf, page 3. Topic 16 is the dedicated primary owner; the premise is retained as the PYQ's wording.

Model solution

A Code of Ethics should open with constitutional fidelity and public purpose, then state selflessness, integrity, merit objectivity, impartiality, openness, honest interest declaration, accountability and leadership by example. It should guide gifts, conflicts, post-employment, use of information, reasoned discretion, citizen treatment and good-faith dissent.

Implementation is decisive: public adoption, confidential ethics advice, induction and scenario training, updated interest registers, recusal protocols, independent complaint handling, fair inquiry and an annual report on observance. Senior officers should record how recurring dilemmas were resolved without exposing protected data.

A Code of Conduct remains complementary because it specifies behaviour, procedures and consequences. An ethics code cannot replace service rules, criminal law or due process, and a symbolic declaration cannot establish probity. The suitable model therefore joins Nolan-type principles with Indian constitutional morality, practical decision support, monitoring and remedy. It should be intelligible to citizens so transparency permits public evaluation of the standards claimed by administration.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 9 - 2024 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q6(a): 'In Indian culture and value system, an equal opportunity has been provided irrespective of gender identity. The number of women in public service has been steadily increasing over the years.' Examine the gender-specific challenges faced by female public servants and suggest suitable measures to increase their efficiency in discharging their duties and maintaining high standards of probity. (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact isolated subpart verified against books\mains\05 UPSC 2024 Paper-IV_Final 1.pdf, page 3. Topic 04 supplies foundational-values depth; Topic 14 owns the probity application.

Model solution

Women public servants may face unsafe field conditions, inadequate sanitation and childcare, sexual harassment, stereotyping in assignments, biased appraisal, disproportionate care burdens and exclusion from informal mentoring networks. These barriers reduce efficiency and can create pressure to rely on patronage or remain silent about misconduct.

Measures include safe infrastructure and transport; functional Internal Committees with time-bound, confidential redress; childcare and gender-neutral flexible work without career penalty; transparent posting and appraisal criteria; structured mentoring; equal access to operational roles; and periodic gender audit of outcomes. Decisions on accommodation should use published eligibility, recorded reasons and review so support does not become favouritism.

High probity is maintained not by demanding exceptional personal sacrifice but by designing institutions that permit impartial and documented performance. Harassment complaints require due process for both complainant and respondent. Equal opportunity is therefore substantive: removing gender-specific barriers improves capability while transparent rules, conflict controls and answerability preserve public trust.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

Solved PYQ 10 - 2025 - 10 marks

Question: GS-IV Q1(b): 'Constitutional morality is not a natural sentiment but a product of civil education and adherence of the rule of law.' Examine the significance of constitutional morality for public servant highlighting the role in promoting good governance and ensuring accountability in public administration. (Answer in 150 words)

Source / ownership: Exact isolated subpart, including the printed spelling 'adherence', verified against books\mains\UPSC Mains 2025 GS Paper 4.pdf, page 2. Social-media ethics in Q1(a) is excluded.

Model solution

Constitutional morality is learned fidelity to constitutional values, procedures and restraints, not an automatic sentiment. Civil education explains equality, liberty, dignity and institutional roles; repeated adherence to rule of law turns those commitments into administrative habit.

For a public servant it requires lawful competence, impartial treatment, hearing, reasoned discretion, respect for minorities, honest advice and acceptance of review. A district officer who rejects popular pressure to exclude a community from relief and publishes neutral eligibility reasons demonstrates constitutional rather than majoritarian morality.

This promotes good governance through predictable rules, transparency, participation and trust. It ensures accountability because reasons and records let legislatures, auditors, courts and citizens test whether power served its authorised purpose and obtain correction. Constitutional morality does not permit private conviction to override valid law; change must use competent constitutional channels. Its significance lies in converting public office from personal authority into disciplined, reviewable service to equal citizens.

Why this earns marks: It states the governing ethical idea, translates it into public administration, uses a concrete Indian illustration, acknowledges a limit, and ends with a reasoned verdict.

ORIGINAL MAINS PRACTICE WITH MODEL SOLUTIONS

Original Mains Practice 1 - 10 marks

Question: Distinguish honesty, integrity, propriety, accountability and probity without arranging them in a rigid hierarchy. Answer in about 150 words.

Model solution

Honesty asks whether a person speaks truthfully, avoids deception and candidly declares relevant interests. Integrity asks whether ethical principle remains consistent under pressure and improper outside obligations. Propriety asks whether conduct is appropriate to the purpose and dignity of office, even where technically lawful. Accountability asks whether a competent forum can demand reasons, examine evidence and secure correction or consequence.

Probity brings these overlapping tests to entrusted public power: is the conduct upright, impartial, public-purpose and capable of reasoned verification? They are not rigid nested sets. An officer may honestly disclose a sibling's bid yet fail propriety and probity by continuing to score it; transparency exists, but accountability remains incomplete without independent review and remedy.

The examiner-safe method is functional comparison, not the claim that honesty is a subset of integrity or probity. Each concept illuminates a different failure point, while sound governance requires them to reinforce one another.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 2 - 10 marks

Question: Why must procedural probity and substantive public purpose be assessed together in administration? Answer in about 150 words.

Model solution

Procedural probity examines authority, notice, equal information, objective criteria, conflict controls, written reasons, records and review. Substantive probity examines whether the decision genuinely serves the authorised public purpose, respects equal citizenship and avoids private capture.

Either can fail alone. A tender may contain perfect forms and scoring sheets but use tailor-made specifications to favour a connected vendor; procedure becomes a facade for an improper end. Conversely, an emergency officer may save lives through a reasonable departure from a minor formality, yet must record necessity, cure the defect and accept review. Good purpose cannot excuse corruption, but literalism should not defeat the law's purpose where lawful discretion exists.

The combined test asks: was the route fair and traceable, and was the destination public-purpose? Written reasons, independent review and proportionate remedy connect both. Probity therefore rejects both results-only administration and compliance theatre.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 3 - 15 marks

Question: Explain the public-office-as-trust idea and critically delimit it from India's settled environmental public-trust doctrine. Answer in about 200 words.

Model solution

Public-office-as-trust is an ethical fiduciary analogy. Citizens entrust authority, information, discretion and public money to officials for authorised purposes; office is therefore not personal property or a source of private favour. The analogy explains duties of loyalty to public purpose, care, impartiality, disclosure of conflicting interests and answerability for reasons.

Its philosophical support is broad. Social-contract reasoning derives authority from citizens; Gandhian trusteeship treats possession and power as stewardship; deontology makes non-corrupt service a duty independent of detection; constitutional morality restrains office through equality, dignity and lawful process. A licensing officer who refuses to use confidential data for a relative acts consistently with this trust framing.

The legal boundary is essential. India's settled environmental public-trust doctrine, associated with cases such as *M.C. Mehta v. Kamal Nath*, concerns State trusteeship of certain natural resources. It should not be cited as a direct holding governing every appointment, tax or procurement decision. Public-office-as-trust is persuasive ethical and administrative reasoning unless a specific legal duty independently applies.

The analogy is useful because it converts power into stewardship, but precise answers separate philosophical extension from positive doctrine and identify the actual statute, service rule or review mechanism governing the case.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 4 - 15 marks

Question: Discuss deontology, virtue ethics, Gandhian trusteeship and constitutional morality as complementary philosophical bases of probity. Answer in about 200 words.

Model solution

Deontology treats truthful, impartial and non-corrupt public action as a duty owed to persons and office, even when misconduct would be undetected or administratively convenient. It protects moral limits but can become mechanical if rules are applied without context.

Virtue ethics asks what kind of public servant institutions cultivate. Habituated integrity, courage and justice make probity stable; phronesis, or practical wisdom, applies those virtues sensitively in unusual cases. Yet character alone needs public controls because citizens cannot audit an official's inner virtue.

Gandhian trusteeship frames power and resources as stewardship for social welfare, while the unity of means and ends rejects bribery or deception even for an attractive project. It is an ethical analogy, not a universal statutory rule. Constitutional morality supplies the Indian public standard: equality, liberty, dignity, institutional competence, reasoned process and review restrain both personal preference and majority pressure.

Together they answer four questions: what duty binds, what character sustains it, whose purpose power serves, and which constitutional limits govern. Institutions then translate philosophy into conflict registers, written reasons, audit, appeal and remedy. Probity is strongest when duty and virtue become publicly verifiable without reducing ethics to forms.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 5 - 20 marks

Question: Design a risk-calibrated probity framework for high-value specialised public procurement without paralysing bona-fide administrative judgment. Answer in about 250 words.

Model solution

High-value specialised procurement combines fiscal exposure, technical information asymmetry, limited competition, safety consequences and wide official discretion. A sound framework must deter capture without assuming every official is corrupt.

First, classify risk by value, discretion, market concentration, safety impact, urgency, past complaints and conflict exposure. Publish functional specifications and evaluation weights after independent market consultation, while protecting legitimate confidential data. Require evaluator interest declarations, recusal where material, segregation of technical and financial roles, equal bidder information and a secure electronic record. For the highest tier, use independent technical members, an incorporated Integrity Pact, beneficial-ownership and agent disclosure, reasoned deviation approval, competition review and milestone-based contract monitoring.

Accountability must continue after award through inspection, change-order controls, payment audit, complaint windows, CVO vigilance coordination and CAG or departmental audit within mandate. Red flags should trigger focused inquiry, not automatic criminal inference. Affected bidders need reasoned debriefing and review; proven loss requires correction, recovery or other lawful remedy.

Bona-fide judgment should receive a safe harbour when authority was verified, material facts disclosed, alternatives considered, reasons contemporaneously recorded and no improper interest existed. The protection defeats hindsight punishment, not audit or appeal. Routine low-risk purchases should face lighter controls so expertise remains available for serious risks.

Thus risk grading reconciles probity with administrative capacity: scrutiny rises with potential harm, while documented good faith, independent review and proportionate remedy preserve decisive, timely and trustworthy public service.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.

Original Mains Practice 6 - 20 marks

Question: You chair a tender committee for essential hospital equipment. A technically strong preferred vendor has supplied the department reliably for years, but its local agent is your former business partner and the tender specifications closely match that vendor's product. Evaluate the options and recommend action. Answer in about 250 words.

Model solution

Stakeholders are patients, competing vendors, taxpayers, hospital staff, the preferred supplier, the local agent, the committee and the chair. The issues are actual or apparent conflict, possible tailor-made specifications, continuity and safety, competition, confidential information and public trust.

The chair could continue after private assurance of fairness; disclose but retain the vote; cancel the process immediately; or disclose, recuse and obtain independent review of the specifications. Silence preserves speed but makes every later decision suspect. Disclosure without recusal may not cure a material former financial relationship. Automatic cancellation wastes time and may disrupt essential care before facts are tested.

I would file a complete written disclosure, cease contact with the agent and recuse from specification and evaluation decisions. The competent authority should appoint an independent chair and technical reviewers. They should test whether each specification follows patient need and interoperability or unnecessarily excludes equivalent products. Any change must be notified equally, with adequate bid time. Existing evaluation data and electronic logs should be preserved.

If only that product can safely meet a documented need, a lawful limited-competition route may be used with market-price benchmarking, recorded reasons, higher approval and post-award audit. If specifications were manipulated, the tender should be corrected or reissued and supported misconduct referred through due process. Urgent interim supply should be narrow, time-bound and separately approved.

The recommendation protects both procedure and public purpose. It does not punish a reliable vendor merely for association, nor permit reliability to become inherited entitlement. Recusal, independent technical judgment, equal information, review and continuity safeguards produce a defensible patient-centred result.

Why this earns marks: The response defines the issue, develops the relevant mechanism with India-centric evidence, tests a limitation, and gives a mark-scaled conclusion.